



Maritime SE Asia

TO THE SOUTH OF THE ASIAN mainland lies maritime Southeast Asia. It includes Malaysia, Indonesia, East Timor, Singapore, and the Philippines. Part of Malaysia is connected to the mainland, but the rest of the region is made up of more than 20,000 islands that stretch across the Pacific and Indian Oceans. Lying near the Equator, the climate is mostly hot, wet, and humid. Most of the larger islands are mountainous and covered in dense forest, and many people live in villages near rivers or on the coast. Like the rest of Southeast Asia, the population is made up of people from many different cultural backgrounds speaking hundreds of different languages. The most common religion is Islam, except in the Philippines, where most people are Roman Catholic.



GREAT APES

The orangutans are great apes that live only in Borneo and the northern corner of Sumatra. They spend most of their time in the trees, even building tree-top nests in which to sleep. Sadly, the orangutan is endangered because of deforestation.



Ubudiah Mosque, Malaysia

PEOPLE OF MALAYSIA

Ethnic Malaysians make up 50 percent of the population and are known as bumiputera, meaning "sons of the soil." Most Malaysians are Muslim. Ethnic Chinese form 23 percent of the population.

Sultan of Brunei



THE SULTAN OF BRUNEI
Brunei is ruled by a sultan who lives in the world's largest palace. The sultan is one of the wealthiest men in the world.



SINGAPORE

As the financial and industrial center of Southeast Asia, Singapore is one of the wealthiest countries in this region. It has a thriving high-tech industry and a high standard of living. There are strictly enforced laws forbidding littering and other small crimes. The death penalty is imposed for drug smuggling. The government also controls the press and restricts the Internet.

Skyscrapers in Singapore's financial district



KITE FLYING

After the harvest, the people of Malaysia celebrate with the Wau-flying (kite-flying) Festival, where skilled people demonstrate the traditional Malaysian sport.

